The Product Development Lifecycle

Where each model fits, which risk each stage retires, and which question you're really answering.

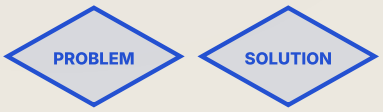
THE SHARED LOOP · A PATTERN, NOT A STANDARD

discover → define → build → launch → measure → iterate ↻

No standards body owns "the PDLC". Ask: **which shape, and which stage of the product?**

THREE SHAPES YOU WILL MEET

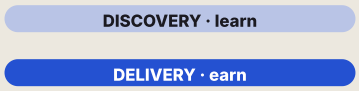
Double Diamond DESIGN COUNCIL



→ the problem itself is unclear

⚠ **doesn't sequence a backlog or measure results**

Dual-track CAGAN · PATTON



→ you ship continuously in one team

⚠ **split across teams = a handoff again**

Shape Up BASECAMP



→ small teams that can cut scope; appetite, not estimates

⚠ **fixed external dates; no extension by default**

Product lifecycle LEVITT, 1965



Intro	Is anyone getting value?	**Maturity**	What do we protect?
Growth	Do new customers stay?	**Decline**	When do we retire it?

⚠ **a lens, not a forecast: stages are clearest in hindsight**

The four risks CAGAN

Value	Will they buy or use it?	**PM**
Usability	Can they figure it out?	Designer
Feasibility	Can we build it?	Engineer
Viability	Does it work for the business?	**PM**

→ tackle value and viability early

⚠ **a prototype customers love is not production**

THE DECISION MAP · NAME THE QUESTION, THEN PICK THE MODEL

DISCOVER
Is it real? Do they want it?
Kano, MVP tests, assumption map, opportunity tree, PMF

DECIDE
Which first? What fits?
RICE, ICE, weighted · Cost of Delay, CD3, WSJF · MoSCoW

BUILD
What goes in this sprint?
the team's cadence

MEASURE
Did it work? Did it break anything?
North Star, metric tree, HEART, funnels, guardrails

LEARN
Real, or noise?
A/B tests, honest readouts; ship, kill or iterate

WHEN THESE MISLEAD YOU

A "standard PDLC": a local habit presented as a rule

A loved prototype: evidence on value and usability only

The lifecycle curve: life can be extended; it's not a forecast

One score for everything: a confident answer to the wrong question

The loop tells you what to do next. The stage tells you what to measure.

Sources: Design Council; Productboard, Dual-Track Agile; Singer, *Shape Up* (2019); Levitt, HBR (1965); Cagan, SVPG: "The Four Big Risks", "Build to Learn vs Build to Earn".